

PREPARED FOR HILARY SHAW AND THE MLSA TEAM

Sixty years showing up for justice. Now, a brand built to show it.

Rebrand, website redesign, and digital strategy.

OCTOBER 2026–MARCH 2027 • LIMINAL

Dear Hilary and the MLSA team,

We're excited about the opportunity to help Montana Legal Services Association mark this next chapter.

Sixty years of free civil legal services to Montanans who could not otherwise afford them is a milestone few organizations reach, and a brand that hasn't kept pace over the years is a solvable challenge.

Your mission statement already makes it clear who you're for as you work to protect and enhance the civil legal rights of, and promote systemic change for, Montanans living in poverty. The challenge is that the rest of the brand doesn't live up to that level of clarity yet, and that gap is exactly what we'd love to work with you to close.

We understand this RFP as an invitation to help MLSA decide, clearly and purposefully, who it is now: an organization reaching more people across a larger and more diverse state than it did decades ago. And you want people to know that you are still rooted in the same commitment to access and dignity. The work is to make sure your name, your voice, your messaging, and your visual identity match the quality of your programming.

These are the very things we care about.

At Liminal, our approach is grounded in these three words: Clarify, Design, Activate. If we have the privilege of working with you, we will help you *clarify* your messaging, elevate your work with the professional *design* you deserve, and help you *activate* your brand with an engaging website that inspires funders to support your mission.

This proposal responds to each requirement in your RFP, followed by our approach, timeline, team, and pricing. We look forward to talking it through with you.

— The Liminal Team

Experience that aligns with your work

We are a branding and communications agency for mission-driven nonprofits working in community development, human rights, international development, and public policy. We help organizations communicate clearly and raise more money.

We bring direct, comparable experience to the table: full rebrands and website builds for mission-driven organizations serving specific, often underserved communities, using the same foundation this project needs. We start with research. Design follows what the research says, and the website turns a list of programs into something a person in crisis can actually use. MLSA's own mission, systemic change alongside direct service, is the kind of equity-centered work Liminal exists to support.

SELECTED WORK

NCCHWA

A brand strategy, new logo, and visual identity, and a bilingual website redesign for a statewide association advocating for community health workers.

ncchwa.org

SELECTED WORK

Restore NYC

A brand refresh, updated messaging, and website redesign for a nonprofit serving survivors of human trafficking, including a new impact page highlighting measurable outcomes for clients.

restorenyc.org

SELECTED WORK

The Sparrows

A rebrand, updated messaging, and a new website for a nonprofit supporting foster and adoptive families, launched in September 2026.

thesparrows.place

SELECTED WORK

Boys & Girls Clubs of the Greater Triad

A brand partnership renewal supporting a multi-market expansion across North Carolina, covering core messaging, visual branding, and graphic design, along with an award-winning website we designed and built for the organization.

bgctriad.org

References

We are happy to connect MLSA with contacts from any of the engagements above, with each client's permission. A starting list follows.

- + Kelly Raudenbush, MA, Executive Director, The Sparrows (kellyraudenbush@sparrowfund.org)
- + Dr. William D. Gibson, President & CEO, Boys & Girls Clubs of the Greater Triad (w.gibson@bgctriad.org)
- + Yvette Holmes, Chief Executive Officer, Southeast Raleigh Promise (yvette@serpromise.org)

Research before recommendations

We will open the engagement with structured discovery: real interviews and surveys, a full asset audit, and a scan of the field, so recommendations rest on what we find rather than a guess.

We've already started. MLSA's current site uses at least four different taglines side by side: "Montana's Solution to Unmet Legal Aid Needs," "Equal Access to Justice," "Fighting Poverty. Achieving Justice. Improving Lives.," and "Justice Lives Here." That reads to us like an organization that has grown faster than its messaging, and closing that gap is exactly what this project can do.

- + Up to six brand interviews and surveys with leadership, including Executive Director Alison Paul, board members, funders, and a sample of current and former clients, conducted in a way that respects confidentiality.
- + A full audit of existing brand assets: MLSA's current logo and print materials, MontanaLawHelp.org, and any regional program branding.
- + A Peer Landscape Analysis showing how other legal aid and access-to-justice organizations position themselves, in Montana and nationally, so we can find where MLSA's story stands apart.
- + A findings memo naming the gap between how MLSA operates today and how its brand currently reads, with clear recommendations for what should change.

An honest approach on the name

Deciding whether to change MLSA's name is strategic work, grounded in research rather than a logo refresh. MLSA already considers systemic reach a core strategy: case selection focuses on issues affecting many people, and programs like MontanaLawHelp.org are built to reach entire populations rather than one client at a time.

We'll evaluate the current name against three questions: does it describe what MLSA does in language a person in crisis would use, does it create confusion or baggage in the communities MLSA is trying to reach, and does it work alongside MontanaLawHelp.org.

If a new name tests well, we'll propose two or three directions, each checked for availability and how each is perceived by funders, partners, and the courts. If the current name should stay, we'll tell you, and we'll put that energy into messaging and visual identity instead. Either way, you get branding expertise and an honest recommendation with the reasoning behind it.

Two concepts, then one complete system

We'll present two concept directions so staff and the board can react to real options together, then decide on one system. Once a direction is chosen, we will build it out completely.

- + Primary and secondary logo marks
- + A color palette and typography system
- + Logo usage guidelines
- + Imagery and photography guidelines
- + A full brand style guide
- + A PowerPoint presentation template
- + Business card and letterhead designs

Language your team approves before anything gets designed

In our process, messaging always comes before design, so the identity work above would be built on language that MLSA approves. Deliverables include core brand message and tagline, a positioning statement, a set of storytelling options staff can pull from directly, and dedicated brand transition messaging for the people who have known MLSA for decades.

Key messages will speak directly to the audiences MLSA already works alongside: the courts, tribal governments and communities served through the Tribal Advocacy Incubator Project, and the universities, foundations, and government partners who fund and refer clients to MLSA's work.

A site built for the people you serve

We'll design and build a new MLSA website that puts client access first. MLSA's current site already gives donors, people seeking help, and volunteers three distinct paths in. We'll keep that structure and strengthen it, while closing a real access gap: the HelpLine hours, Tuesday through Thursday, 9 AM to 1 PM, leave most of the week without live phone support, so the new site needs stronger self-service resources for people who need help outside that window.

- + Full design and development of the new site
- + CMS selection based on MLSA's staff capacity and long-term maintenance needs
- + Content migration from the current site
- + On-site search
- + Spanish-language content support
- + Accessibility built to WCAG 2.1 AA guidelines, tested with assistive technology as well as automated scanners
- + Quality assurance and cross-browser testing before launch
- + Documentation and hands-on training for MLSA's website editors

A rollout your partners and funders can follow

We'll build a rollout plan that sequences the announcement across MLSA's own channels, partner organizations, funders, and local media, with messaging that explains why the change happened and what stays the same: MLSA's mission and the people it serves.

The plan includes implementation guidance so MLSA's team knows what to update and when, from email signatures to court filings.

Clarify, Design, Activate

Liminal engagements move through three phases. This structure lines up directly with MLSA's own milestones for discovery, visual identity, the brand style guide, and the implementation plan.

PHASE 1

Clarify

Discovery, the renaming analysis, and messaging, so nothing gets designed before it's been tested in language.

PHASE 2

Design

The visual identity, brand collateral, and the new website, built on what Clarify confirmed.

PHASE 3

Activate

Launch planning, staff training, and the transition itself.

From signed contract to launch in five months

DATES	PHASE	WHAT HAPPENS
Oct 26, 2026	Contract & kickoff	Signed contract, project kickoff.
Late Oct – early Dec 2026	Phase 1: Clarify	Brand interviews and surveys, brand audit, renaming analysis, messaging strategy.
Early Dec 2026 – mid Jan 2027	Phase 2: Design	Visual identity concepts, brand style guide, website design and development.
Mid Jan – March 2027	Phase 3: Activate	QA, staff training, content migration, rollout planning and launch.

A note on the RFP deadline: the RFP lists February 30, 2027 as the deadline for completing the brand audit, stakeholder interviews, and review of current branding, a date that doesn't exist on the calendar. Per the RFP's own instructions, we'll confirm the intended deadline with Hilary Shaw in writing. Our Phase 1 work above wraps by early December 2026, well ahead of whatever that date turns out to be.

The people you'll work with

Everyone listed here works on the project. No handoff to someone you haven't met.



ACCOUNT LEAD

Kemah Washington

Chief Growth Officer. Your primary point of contact from the first call through the final handoff. Keeps the work moving and the scope honest.



ENGAGEMENT LEAD

Bill Cummings

CEO and Co-Founder. Runs the kickoff session and the leadership interviews, writes the brand strategy, and presents the findings.



ART DIRECTION

CC Esguerra

Art Director. Leads the visual identity and sets the direction the website design follows.



PROJECT MANAGEMENT

Gracia Zelaya

Senior Project Manager. Owns the schedule and the interview logistics across six departments, so your team spends its time on substance.



MESSAGING

Hannah Sherk

Content Specialist. Turns what your team said into language they recognize. Writes the core narrative, the service area messaging, and the guide your departments will use.



WEBSITE DEVELOPMENT

Ben Cummings

Builds the site on the recommended CMS, migrates existing content, and implements accessibility and cross-browser testing before launch.

What each phase costs

The figures below are a working estimate built to fit MLSA's stated budget of \$25,000 to \$30,000. That range is tight for a full rebrand, website redesign, and rollout plan, so we built the phases at the top of it and weighted the money toward the visual identity and website work. If new scope comes up once we're underway, we'll raise it before it changes the total.

Clarify

\$7,500

Phase 1

Discovery, interviews, the renaming analysis, and messaging strategy.

Design

\$20,000

Phase 2

Visual identity, brand style guide, collateral, and the website build.

Activate

\$2,500

Phase 3

QA, staff training, content migration, and rollout planning.

Total investment: \$30,000 for Clarify, Design, and Activate combined.

Additional expenses

The following items sit outside the base fee above and are billed only if MLSA chooses them.

- + Stock photography or licensing. Billed at cost, only if MLSA's own photography isn't sufficient.
- + CMS hosting or licensing fees. Billed directly by the provider, not included in Liminal's fee.
- + Printed collateral production. Design is included in the base fee; print production is billed separately.
- + Full-site Spanish translation, if MLSA wants a complete parallel Spanish site.

Hourly rates

For any work requested outside this proposal's defined scope, Liminal bills at the following rates.

- + Strategy and creative direction: \$175/hr
- + Design: \$150/hr
- + Content and copywriting: \$125/hr
- + Website development: \$150/hr
- + Project management: \$100/hr

Compensation and proposal validity

Liminal requests a 50 percent deposit at contract signing, with the remaining balance billed at three milestones: completion of Clarify, completion of Design, and project launch. This proposal is valid for 60 days from the date of submission.

Ready when MLSA is.

MLSA has spent sixty years building trust one case at a time. We'd like to help make sure the brand reflects that same trust into its next sixty years. We're ready to start as soon as MLSA is.

— The Liminal Team

Kemah E. P. Washington, Ed.D., Chief Growth Officer

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